DEALS IN PROCESS

SHIPS

Four Admiral Grigorivich-class stealth frigates, two to be built in India in a deal worth roughly $4 billion. In March 2019, India signed an agreement to lease one Akula-class nuclear submarine, *Chakra III*, for $3 billion.



AIRCRAFT



200 Kamov 226-T helicopters, 140 of which were to be built in India for about $1 billion. India is also in advanced talks with Russia for 12 Sukhoi Su-30MKI aircraft, to be built in the country by Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd at a cost of about Rs 10,730 crore.

OTHERS

On the table is a deal to buy 464 T-90MS battle tanks, at about $1.9 billion. India and Russia recently signed a deal under which some 600,000 AK 203-7 assault rifles will be manufactured under licence at a factory in Amethi.

MISSILES

Import plans include ammunition and ordnance for various existing rocket platforms, including man-portable 'very short range' defence systems. There is an ongoing deal for five Triumf S-400 missile defence systems for nearly $5.5 billion, of which four are yet to be delivered.



TREADING A MIDDLE PATH, INDIA ABSTAINED FROM VOTING IN THE UNSC, BUT PUT OUT AN EXPLANATORY NOTE FAIRLY CRITICAL OF RUSSIA

proceed with his Ukraine invasion. As Andrew Small, a Senior Transatlantic Fellow at German Marshall Fund of the US and a China expert, says, "This is not just a Russia question. It is a 'Russia enabled by China' question, and European leaders have been remarkably explicit about Beijing's involvement in the Security Council on this." The broader fear for the European security order, according to Small, is that if Putin succeeds in Ukraine, he is likely to move in menacingly on the Baltic states. So, one has to draw the red line early. By imposing tough sanctions, the US and Europe are also sending China a clear warning of the consequences it would face if it tried to take Taiwan by force. Tellis agrees. "China ought to learn from Russia's Ukraine experience," he says. "If they had any romantic notions of getting the Taiwanese to surrender in 48 hours, they should now know how wrong they could be—that they might have to pay a much heavier price." Adds Menon, "Nobody in Taiwan is inviting Xi to come in, for him to claim it is a threat to his security. The cost is also in terms of how much Chinese blood he is willing to spill."

Former foreign secretary Shyam Saran says the main concern is that it may suit China to use Russia as a cat's paw to disrupt America's pivot to Asia. As he puts it, "If the US identifies Russia as its main adversary and gets embroiled in European security issues, it will obviously dilute its earlier projection that China is the biggest challenge. This has implications for its Indo-Pacific strategy and the Quad grouping, of which India is a part." Varma concurs, saying, "China must be laughing and doing the *bhangra* all the way to the bank. Russia is now like a geopolitical ATM for it." He also believes that with Russia likely to be considerably weakened by the war, "the gates of Central Asia are now open for China to walk in and take control."

Tellis, though, begs to differ, arguing that there is a difference between the two issues. "The China problem," he says, "derives from strength compared to the crisis in Europe, which implicates Russia, a fundamentally weak power. America cannot afford to dissipate its resolve or resources when dealing with China. But we are a superpower and can deal with both these threats simultaneously." Nor will China want to get too closely entangled in Russia's problems and turn fully against the US and Europe for Moscow's sake. Relations with both of them